
ROYAL TRAIN

Chennai Egmore–Kollam Junction Express, *Sengottai–Punalur*



For over a century, the small town of Sengottai was a part of an important rail link, which connected the Madras Presidency with Kollam, the capital of the Travancore kingdom and now in Kerala. Passing through the foothills of the Western Ghats, the line connected the south-western coast with the south-eastern side. It was crucial for the trade and transportation of spices and cashew. The train became popular with the royal families as well. The Sengottai–Punalur section, however, became popular for its scenic beauty. The section closed in 2010 while the line was converted from metre to broad gauge, reopening in 2018. Travel by the Chennai–Kollam line, considered a reincarnation of the original royal line inaugurated in 1904, to take in the lush Ghats and admire the iconic 102-m 13 Kannara or 13-Arch Bridge that curves to connect two hills. Along the way, as the train enters the Aryankavu Tunnel, try to spot a conch engraved into the pillars, a symbol of the Travancore dynasty.



The 13–Arch bridge